



VALLEY OAK CUSTOMS

Design Manager

User Manual

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Find it. Organize it. Open it. Make it.

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1 Product overview and safety model

Design Manager catalogs CNC files in their existing Windows folders. It is an organizer and visual browser, not CAD, CAM, or a machine controller.

- Normal browsing, organization, previewing, and migration do not move or change CNC source files.
- TAP and NC files can be inspected or shown in File Explorer but are never executed.
- Rename, Archive, and Move to Recycle Bin are deliberate real-file actions that require confirmation.

2 Installation upgrades and licensing

Install from the trusted Valley Oak Customs package. An in-place upgrade from the current public version preserves the profile, license, settings, and Local or Shared mode.

- A Local Workspace stays Local. Migration begins only when explicitly selected.
- Library folders, saved organization, Workflow history, relationships, and license state are retained.
- Use Settings > License to activate or deactivate this PC. A Design Manager 1.x license continues working offline after activation.
- Viewer Mode preserves safe access. A dead or rebuilt PC activation reset is reviewed by Valley Oak support.

3 Main screen and daily workflow

Use the left filters, center library, and right Details panel together.

- Search filenames, folders, tags, notes, and status.
- Select once for details; double-click a supported file to open it.
- The display-first Details panel keeps common actions near the top. Choose Edit when you need to change saved design information.
- For an SVG or DXF, Open Design Workspace provides a design-centered manufacturing view.

4 Libraries folders and file types

Design Library Folders supply the normal browser. Workflow locations can contain JOB, TAP, or NC files without becoming design-card libraries.

- SVG and DXF receive artwork previews. Images can be browsed or used as supporting material. SheetCam JOB files use available companion artwork when supported.
- TAP and NC are G-code Programs and use the dedicated safe machine-file preview.
- Add Local roots and Include subfolders under Settings > Design Library Folders. Shared roots are Administrator-managed and mapped per PC.

5 Search favorites Controlled Tags collections and status

These tools organize files without moving them.

- Search checks filenames, folders, tags, notes, and status. Filters narrow the visible library.
- Favorites mark frequent work; collections make virtual groups; status records shop readiness.
- Controlled Tags keep suggested names consistent while preserving deliberate user-created tags.

6 File actions and batch tools

Batch organization changes saved metadata. Real-file actions require careful confirmation.

- Hide removes a file from normal browsing.
- Rename changes the disk filename. Archive moves the file. Move to Recycle Bin uses Windows Recycle Bin.
- Shared mode disables unsupported source-file operations rather than risking inconsistent metadata.

7 Design details and shop information

Use the Details panel to record information useful on the next run.

- Store dimensions, material, finish, cut time, test results, and customer notes where useful.
- Saved automatically confirms pending organization changes were written.

8 Preview Studio

Preview Studio exports a separate PNG proof from SVG or DXF.

- Choose artwork, background, branding, proof text, size, and padding.
- For complex DXF contours, As drawn / cut lines is the safest view.
- The source SVG or DXF remains unchanged.

9 Design Workspace

Design Workspace keeps one SVG or DXF anchored while showing its saved design information and manufacturing files together.

- Open it from the selected design using Open Design Workspace. Back to Library returns to the library without changing the saved relationships.
- Confirmed Design to JOB to TAP/NC relationships retain their hierarchy. Direct Design to machine-file links appear in a separate group.
- Suggested relationships are visually separate and require Review before they become active. Availability labels distinguish available, missing, inaccessible or unverified, and ignored evidence.
- Preview and Reveal use the existing safe file actions. Returning from Preview, minimizing, or switching windows preserves the current Design Workspace view.

10 Related Files and automatic discovery

Related Files preserves the many-to-many reality of shop work. Discovery creates review candidates; it does not make inferred relationships authoritative.

- A JOB can contain several Designs. A Design can belong to several JOBS. A JOB can have several TAP or NC programs.
- Design Manager uses filenames, locations, file types, and bounded context to suggest candidates. Manual decisions outrank later discovery.
- When a confirmed Design to JOB connection already explains a machine program, redundant direct Design to machine suggestions are kept out of normal review.
- View related files shows confirmed active connections and Workflow History for the selected file.

Relationship history: Design Manager keeps earlier choices so you can restore a relationship later.

11 Needs Review

Needs Review contains suggestions that still require a decision.

- Open it from a selected design to see direct suggestions plus unresolved machine-file suggestions beneath that design's confirmed JOBS. Choose Show all needs review for the global queue.
- Sort columns and inspect both paths, types, dates, context, and match reasons.
- Choose Confirm to make the pair active or Not related to retain an explicit rejection. A reconsidered pair remains inactive until Confirm succeeds.

12 All Workflow Files

All Workflow Files includes workflow-only locations and files absent from the normal browser.

- Launch from a selected design to keep its confirmed manufacturing context. Choose Show all workflow files for the global list.
- Use Find and sortable columns in large libraries.
- Preview or Show in folder safely before deciding.

13 Saved Relationships and states

Saved Relationships retains decisions and history for each pair.

- Confirmed is active. Removed is retained history and is inactive.
- Reconsidered returns an existing pair to Needs Review; it remains inactive until confirmed.
- Superseded preserves an older choice replaced by a correction. Restore relationship reactivates a saved connection when allowed.
- Choose different file uses the protected correction flow so old and replacement states remain traceable.

14 Workflow History

View related files shows the selected path, current-file role, active related items, and recorded Workflow activity.

- A JOB shows its directly related Designs and G-code. A Design shows its direct JOBs and appropriate G-code through them.
- Use Add or Associate actions to connect a file manually when automatic matching is not enough.
- Design Manager records its own activity and file changes it noticed. The PC name identifies which computer noticed the change, not who edited the source file.
- History remains available when a relationship is removed, reconsidered, or superseded.

15 Choose a related file

The picker keeps the current file fixed while you choose the other side.

- Likely related opens first and ranks compatible candidates using existing match evidence.
- Preview inspects a candidate through its safe existing preview path. Show in folder reveals the exact selected file.
- Show all compatible files restores the complete searchable list for unusual or historical filenames.
- Files with the same name under different roots remain distinct. Repeat Add another Design for mixed-sheet JOBs.

16 TAP and NC safe previews

The machine-file preview renders supported TAP and NC geometry without executing machine instructions.

- Use fit, pan, and the traverse display to inspect the visual path.
- A preview is not CAM verification, postprocessor approval, machine simulation, or proof that a program is safe to run.
- Design Manager does not provide an Open or Run action for TAP or NC programs.

17 Folder exclusions and workflow search

Normal browsing and related-file search are separate choices.

- Local folder exclusions hide selected subfolders from normal scans without deleting files or saved organization.
- A workflow location can still be searched for related files without appearing as a normal design library.
- A new writable Local Workspace starts with a safe default Workflow policy. After changing Local search locations, Refresh related files applies the saved settings and scans without administrator setup.
- Local exclusions are unavailable while Shared Workspace is active; Shared roots are Administrator-managed.

18 Local and Shared behavior

The same organization and relationship terms apply in both modes.

- Local choices stay in the current PC profile. A normal upgrade does not migrate them.
- Shared metadata and Workflow decisions converge between registered PCs with conflict protection.
- Unavailable or incompatible Shared storage preserves the view and blocks unsafe writes.

19 Shared Workspace setup and Local migration

Settings offers Create / Connect Shared Workspace and Migrate Existing Local Workspace to Shared.

- Migration first shows a review preview, preserves the source fingerprint, and creates a complete Local backup before staged Shared cutover. Canceling before approval leaves Local authoritative and the destination untouched.
- Migration imports supported Local organization and Workflow state without moving CNC files. Create Empty Shared Workspace does not copy Local organization.
- Connect joins an existing workspace after connection and compatibility checks.

20 Multiple Shared library roots

A Shared Workspace can have more than one authoritative library root.

- The Administrator adds, removes, and orders authoritative roots. Root identity and ordering are shared.
- Each PC maps every Shared root to the local drive or UNC path that reaches the same content. Paths may differ; root meaning must match.
- During migration, review each source-to-destination root mapping. Unmapped or ambiguous roots stop safely.

21 Administrator Members and recovery

The first authorized Shared device becomes Workspace Administrator; other registered PCs are Members.

- Members perform ordinary Shared organization and Workflow work. The Administrator manages roots, Shared settings, upgrades, backups, devices, recovery designation, and authority transfer.
- Designate at least one Member as a Recovery Device. If the Administrator PC is lost, an eligible Recovery Device can use the protected Recover Administrator flow.
- Stale administrator or device changes are rejected and require Refresh instead of overwriting newer work.

22 Shared offline conflicts and startup

Shared mode reuses verified saved discovery state at startup and reconciles library changes separately.

- Opening Workflow does not require a full rescan when valid state exists. Refresh related files remains the explicit recheck action.
- If Shared metadata storage is unavailable, Design Manager changes to OFFLINE - READ ONLY. Shared edits are blocked and are not queued.
- After access returns, Refresh reads current state. Stale writes are rejected instead of losing another PC's update.
- A slow or unavailable CNC library is reported separately when Shared metadata itself remains reachable.

23 Shared upgrades returning and conversion

The Administrator can upgrade an eligible Shared Workspace after a verified backup.

- Update participating PCs before enabling newer Shared Workflow features. Older incompatible clients fail closed or remain read-only.
- Return to Previous Local Workspace creates a verified Shared backup, reconnects this PC to its preserved earlier Local profile, and does not import later Shared changes.
- Convert Shared Workspace to New Local creates a separate Local copy from current Shared metadata after backup; it does not overwrite the previous Local Workspace.

Plan the upgrade: Update participating PCs before normal Shared use resumes after a workspace upgrade.

24 Settings LightBurn Dashboard and updates

Settings contains libraries, Workflow, appearance, licensing, integrations, updates, and maintenance.

- Configure and Test Connection for LightBurn per PC. Open in LightBurn supports SVG and DXF and leaves the source unchanged.
- Dashboard integration is configured per PC when the supported Valley Oak dashboard is installed.
- Check for Updates is manual. It sends a read-only request only when selected and opens the official update page only after a verified result.

25 Backups export and restore

Design Manager backups protect settings, Workflow choices, and organization; source CNC files need their own backup.

- Local export and restore operate on Local profile data. Verify expected paths before Repair.
- Shared backups are manual and metadata-only. Shared restore validates a complete backup and writes to a new or empty recovery directory; it never overwrites the active workspace.
- Keep independent backups of actual CNC folders. Per-PC mappings and integration paths remain local.

26 Repair diagnostics and storage locations

Repair previews stale references and protects unavailable folders. Diagnostics gathers support information without copying design files.

- Reconnect drives and shares before Repair; cancel when an expected folder is unavailable.
- Local state is under the Design Manager Local AppData profile. Shared metadata is in the selected .valleyoak-workspace folder.
- Use Open Backups or Open Shared Backups to locate recovery packages. Review diagnostics before sharing.

27 Troubleshooting

Clear filters, Refresh, verify Windows access, and read the visible status message.

- Missing related file: inspect Needs Review, All Workflow Files, and Saved Relationships.
- Shared offline: restore access to the Shared metadata folder, then Refresh. Do not create a replacement workspace over an unavailable share.
- Large libraries can take time to reconcile. If the application remains usable and no offline warning appears, allow the current check to finish.
- Support: include version, steps, exact message text, PC name, and diagnostics.

Appendix A Status and relationship reference

Use consistent values so history stays understandable.

Customer term	Meaning
Current	The current file generation.
Older file	A historical file generation.
Confirmed	An active saved relationship.
Removed	Inactive retained history.
Reconsidered	Inactive and returned to Needs Review.
Superseded	An older choice replaced by a newer correction.

Appendix B Backup checklist

Verify every layer before a PC move, upgrade, or recovery.

- Actual CNC folders have an independent backup.
- The Design Manager backup verifies successfully.
- Expected drives and shares are online before Repair.

Appendix C Glossary

The main Workflow uses ordinary shop terms.

Term	Plain-language meaning
Design	SVG or DXF artwork.
SheetCam JOB	A saved SheetCam project.
G-code Program	TAP or NC machine output.
Related Files	Saved connections between files.
Design Workspace	A design-centered view of saved design information and manufacturing files.